trade was a pre-eminent reason for this.[31] In the nineteenth century, BI was in intense competition with P&O. By the turn of the century, German and Japanese lines too joined the fray. After William Mackinnon died in 1893, BI prospered further under a ruthless James Mackay (later Lord Inchcape); if anything, he made Mackinnon appear as a saint.[32] Lord Inchcape 'raised the B.I. concern to the foremost place in world shipping', pulling off a successful merger with P&O during World War I.[33]

Given BI's clout, new entrants into Indian foreign trade, such as Bibby, Brocklebanks or the Austro-Hungarian Lloyds, had no option but to make through-traffic agreements with BI that precluded or limited coasting voyages in Indian waters. At the Colombo conference (1902), an arrangement was arrived at concerning routes, interchange of passengers and cargo, spheres of influence, freight rates and the like. BI also entered into an alliance with the Asiatic Steam Navigation Company, which evolved into the pooling of earnings on the Calcutta–Bombay and Calcutta–Burma routes and joint-charter operations on other lines. Other alliances that it profited from were with Apcar and Company and Jardine Skinner and Company on the Calcutta–Singapore line.[34] Needless to add, indigenous Indian companies were not a part of such arrangements. Compete, undercut and destroy was the policy reserved for indigenous rivals.

It was against this backdrop that Tuticorin found its place on the maritime map. A monthly line between Calcutta and Bombay was calling at Tuticorin as early as in 1863.[35] But developments were slow. In 1874, Mackinnon had wanted the 'home line' and the India lines to work together: boats were to do a regular service to and from London, Colombo, Madras and Calcutta. Consequently, at Colombo, an interchange of traffic for the Tuticorin and Malabar Coast was planned.[36] Even though services on the Coromandel Coast had expanded by the 1870s,[37] it was not until 1894 that a regular Tuticorin and Colombo service was inaugurated.[38] Key to the discussion about the Tuticorin–Colombo line was the emigration of indentured labourers to the tea estates of Ceylon. An agreement was